

“‘I’m gonna make him an offer he can’t refuse.’”

Don Vito Corleone / The Godfather

non-Italian girl, Kay, played by Diane Keaton. He appears to have every hope of living a crime-free life, of fulfilling the American Dream. Pacino, then a little-known actor, received an Oscar nomination for Actor in a Supporting Role.

Family destiny

Michael is drawn inexorably into the gangster world of the Corleone family, finally pledging by his father’s hospital bed, “I’ll take care of you now. I’m with you now. I’m with you.” When his brother Sonny (James Caan) is gunned down, Michael becomes the new heir apparent. His descent from a bright hope is the movie’s central tragedy, yet we understand how strongly he feels that he has no choice. Don Corleone had wanted Michael to become a senator or a governor, but the movie hints that such respectability will always be

out of reach of their family. They may have senators in their pockets but, in public, the senators will always shun them.

The sequel

The Godfather: Part II returns to the Corleone family once Michael has taken control. While he may have been reluctant to step into his father’s shoes, Michael soon loses both his morality and the family’s respectable aspirations. Unlike his father, Michael no longer has ties to Sicily, the “old country,” and its code of honor, however skewed and violent. Nor does he have the same belief in the New World. He becomes, in the end, more brutal than old Don Corleone. ■

Sonny (James Caan, left) is Corleone’s eldest son. When his brother-in-law Carlo (Gianni Russo) hits Connie, Sonny beats up Carlo in the street.



Francis Ford Coppola
Director

Coppola was born in 1939 to a Detroit family of Italian descent. His father Carmine was a composer who would work on the scores of *The Godfather: Part II* and *Apocalypse Now*. In his early twenties, Francis enrolled in the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA) film school, and was soon writing screenplays for Hollywood. He began making movies during the New Hollywood movement, also referred to as the American New Wave, which aimed to tackle new subjects using different styles. *The Godfather*, one of the highest grossing movies in history, was the first major movie he directed, and he cemented his reputation with a string of hits throughout the 1970s. Considered one of America’s most energetic, if erratic, filmmakers, his later movies have not quite matched his early successes.

Key movies

1972 *The Godfather*
1974 *The Conversation*
1974 *The Godfather: Part II*
1979 *Apocalypse Now*